

THE BUSINESS OF GENDER DIVISION

How attention-driven social-media models can profit from polarization

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ABSTRACT

Social-media platforms do not need to manufacture gender conflict in order to profit from it. Their commercial systems are commonly built around advertising, behavioural prediction and the continuous optimization of user attention. Within this structure, content that provokes anger, validation, fear or moral disagreement may acquire a distributional advantage because it generates measurable reactions. Gender-related disputes are especially durable: they touch identity, relationships, safety, status and social expectations, allowing the same antagonistic narratives to be repackaged repeatedly for different audiences. This article develops a conceptual account of how user activity, personalized recommendations, creator incentives and advertising monetization can form a self-reinforcing cycle. Using Meta as a financial and technological case study, it distinguishes evidence of an engagement-based incentive structure from the stronger and presently unproven claim that platforms intentionally create gender hostility. It concludes that the central policy problem is not simply harmful speech, but a market architecture in which socially divisive attention can become economically valuable.

Keywords: attention economy; gender polarization; recommendation algorithms; Meta; online outrage; advertising; creator economy

Author note

This article is a conceptual and desk-based analysis. It does not report original platform data or establish the amount of revenue attributable specifically to gender-polarizing content.

1. Introduction

Social media has become one of the main environments in which people learn what men and women supposedly want, fear, deserve and owe one another. The most visible content in this environment is not necessarily the most representative. A careful discussion of unequal care work, male loneliness, sexual violence, false allegations, workplace discrimination or changing expectations in marriage may struggle to travel as widely as a categorical accusation aimed at an entire gender. The reason is not mysterious: nuance asks for patience, while conflict produces an immediate reason to stop, react and return.

This article examines a specific proposition: social-media platforms do not necessarily create gender conflict from nothing, but attention-driven business models can reward, amplify and repeatedly monetize it. The claim is structural rather than conspiratorial. It does not require executives to direct an algorithm to make men and women distrust each other. It requires only a system that learns which material retains attention and a revenue model that benefits when users remain active, generate behavioural signals and encounter more advertisements.

The argument must also be stated with discipline. Evidence that engagement-based ranking amplifies emotionally charged or hostile material does not, by itself, prove that a particular platform intentionally promotes misogyny, misandry or gender antagonism. Nor does publicly available financial reporting identify how much advertising revenue appears beside gender-polarizing content. The defensible conclusion is narrower: where divisive gender narratives reliably produce watch time, comments, shares, rewatches and response content, they can fit exceptionally well within an economy that converts engagement into commercial value.

2. Concepts, Method and Scope

2.1 Gender polarization and depolarization

Gender polarization refers to the cultural treatment of masculinity and femininity as opposing, internally uniform and mutually exclusive categories. In a polarized framework, occupations, emotions, styles and duties are classified as naturally male or naturally female: boys are directed toward toughness and mechanical competence, while girls are directed toward care, beauty and emotional sensitivity. Sandra Bem described gender polarization as one of the cultural lenses through which sex differences are extended into a much wider social division (Bem, 1993).

Gender depolarization is the more accurate counterpart to this concept. It does not require the erasure of gender or the denial of sex-based realities. It permits overlap. Men may be vulnerable, nurturing or aesthetically expressive without being treated as deficient men; women may lead, compete or perform mechanical work without being treated as deficient women. This distinction matters because social-media conflict often converts flexible, contextual questions into binary camps: traditional versus modern, masculine versus feminine, victim versus oppressor, or freedom versus accountability.

2.2 Method

The article uses a qualitative desk-research method. It synthesizes scholarship on moral-emotional diffusion, social reinforcement, perceived intergroup hostility and engagement-based ranking; public disclosures concerning Meta's recommendation and advertising systems; and emerging platform audits concerning gender-hostile content. The approach is explanatory rather than causal. It identifies a plausible commercial mechanism and evaluates how well available evidence supports each stage of that mechanism.

The evidence base has an important imbalance. Research on online misogyny, the manosphere and harmful content directed at women is more developed than research on organized anti-male hostility or the newer "femosphere." Accordingly, this article uses the broader expression gender-

antagonistic content while acknowledging that the strongest empirical examples presently concern misogynistic content and political forms of out-group hostility.

3. The Attention Economy: What Platforms Actually Sell

Human attention is limited. In information-rich environments, the scarcity is not content but the capacity to notice and process it - a problem long associated with Herbert Simon's account of attention scarcity (Simon, 1971). Social-media platforms convert this scarcity into a market. For users, the service may appear free; for advertisers, the platform offers access to audiences whose likely interests and actions can be estimated from behavioural data.

Every pause, like, comment, share, follow, profile visit, search, skip and rewatch can function as a signal. These signals help recommendation systems estimate which content a person may value or engage with next. Meta has publicly explained that its systems combine numerous predictions, including the likelihood that a user will share a post, to rank Feed, Reels, Stories and content from accounts the user does not follow (Meta, 2023). The same activity supports advertising personalization by helping the platform decide which advertisement is most likely to produce an impression, click or conversion.

The commercial sequence can therefore be summarized as follows:



Figure 1. Simplified commercial feedback loop in an advertising-supported recommendation platform.

This loop does not mean that every interaction is equally valuable or that platforms simply maximize raw screen time. Modern systems balance multiple objectives, including predicted satisfaction, safety, freshness, relevance and advertiser performance. Nevertheless, engagement remains commercially consequential because it expands the inventory of attention that can be monetized and improves the data available for future predictions.

4. Meta as a Case Study in Personalization and Monetization

Meta provides a useful case study because its financial filings and product disclosures make the connection between engagement, recommendation quality and advertising performance unusually visible. The figures below do not measure gender polarization. They establish the economic structure within which attention-generating content operates.

Indicator	Reported figure	Analytical relevance
Total revenue, 2025	\$200.966 billion	Overall economic scale of the company
Advertising revenue, 2025	\$196.175 billion	Approximately 97.6% of total revenue
Advertising revenue growth	22% year-on-year	Expansion of the advertising model
Ad-impression growth	12% year-on-year	More delivered opportunities to display ads
Average price per ad	9% year-on-year increase	Higher value per advertising unit
Family daily active people, Dec. 2025	3.58 billion	Scale at which personalization operates
Facebook organic Feed/video views, Q4 2025	7% lift from ranking improvements	Direct engagement effect of recommendation changes
Threads time spent, Q4 2025	20% lift from optimizations	Recommendation changes increased attention
Facebook ad clicks, Q4 2025	3.5% lift from ad-ranking changes	Ranking quality translated into user action

Indicator	Reported figure	Analytical relevance
Instagram conversions, Q4 2025	>1% gain from ad-ranking changes	Personalization improved advertiser outcomes

Table 1. Meta 2025 financial and product indicators. Sources: Meta Platforms, Inc. (2026a, 2026b). Figures rounded only where indicated.

Meta reported total revenue of \$200.966 billion for 2025, including \$196.175 billion in advertising revenue. Advertising therefore accounted for approximately 97.6% of total revenue. The company also reported a 12% increase in ad impressions and a 9% increase in average price per ad. It attributed impression growth partly to increases in users and engagement, and price growth partly to improvements in ad targeting and measurement tools (Meta Platforms, Inc., 2026a).

The connection between prediction and commercial performance is even clearer in Meta's product reporting. The company stated that Q4 2025 Feed and video-ranking improvements produced a 7% lift in views of organic Facebook content, while optimizations produced a 20% lift in time spent on Threads. Changes to ad-ranking systems reportedly produced a 3.5% lift in Facebook ad clicks and more than a 1% gain in Instagram conversions (Meta Platforms, Inc., 2026b). These disclosures show that relatively small changes in ranking performance can matter at enormous scale.

The appropriate inference is not that Meta earns 97.6% of its revenue from polarization. It is that Meta earns almost all of its revenue from advertising, while personalized ranking can increase both attention and advertiser outcomes. Content capable of producing repeated, high-intensity engagement therefore enters a system with a clear route from behavioural response to economic value.

5. Why Conflict Performs

Conflict has several properties that make it legible to recommendation systems. It creates fast reactions, invites public positioning and generates participation from opponents as well as supporters. A user who comments in anger may dislike the message, but the interaction still tells the system that the content was sufficiently important to interrupt passive scrolling.

Research on moral-emotional language helps explain this advantage. In a study of 563,312 social-media messages concerning polarizing public issues, Brady and colleagues found that each additional moral-emotional word was associated with roughly a 20% increase in diffusion, particularly within ideological networks (Brady et al., 2017). A later study examining 7,331 users and 12.7 million tweets found that social rewards for expressions of moral outrage increased the probability of future outrage expression, consistent with reinforcement learning (Brady et al., 2021). The platform does not simply distribute outrage; its visible rewards can teach creators and ordinary users that outrage works.

There is also a gap between what users engage with and what they would choose upon reflection. A preregistered audit published in PNAS Nexus found that engagement-based ranking amplified emotionally charged and out-group-hostile political content relative to a reverse-chronological feed, even though users did not report preferring the algorithmically selected material (Milli et al., 2025). In 2026, a randomized eight-week study involving 2,000 participants found that engagement-based feeds amplified intergroup, moralized, emotional and toxic content, with especially large increases in moral outrage, and increased perceived partisan animosity (Brady et al., 2026).

These studies concern political or moral conflict rather than gender alone. Their relevance is mechanistic. Gender disputes frequently contain the same features: group identity, accusations of injustice, moral judgment, threat and emotionally expressive language. They therefore offer a reason to expect that engagement-based systems may treat gender antagonism as high-performing material, even when the system has no concept of gender reconciliation or social harm.

6. Why Gender Conflict Is an Especially Durable Product

Gender conflict is not a single trend. It is a reusable narrative framework. The same oppositional structure can be applied to dating, marriage, divorce, domestic labour, sexual behaviour, workplace advancement, beauty, money, parenting, violence, loneliness and political representation. Because nearly every user has personal experience of gendered expectations or intimate relationships, creators can translate abstract ideology into emotionally familiar stories.

The content also travels in paired markets. One creator tells men that women are manipulative, hypergamous or ungrateful. Another tells women that men are inherently predatory, emotionally unavailable or socially unnecessary. Each side can use the excesses of the other as evidence. A hostile post is clipped, mocked and circulated across an opposing community, where it generates a second round of attention. In this way, counter-speech may correct a claim while simultaneously extending its commercial life.

Emerging gender-specific audits illustrate the risk, although they should be interpreted cautiously. The UCL and University of Kent Safer Scrolling project analysed more than 1,000 videos shown to archetypal young male TikTok profiles and reported a fourfold increase in misogynistic recommendations over five days (Regehr et al., 2024). A 2025 Princeton undergraduate thesis used 18 controlled Instagram accounts to investigate pathways from personalization to gender-based hate; it provides useful exploratory evidence but is not a peer-reviewed platform-wide estimate (Neske, 2025). Such studies cannot establish a universal result across all users, countries or periods, but they demonstrate why gender-hostile recommendation pathways deserve direct, reproducible auditing.

7. Creator Incentives and Polarization Entrepreneurs

The platform is only one actor in the system. Creators observe performance in real time. When a balanced video receives limited reach but a sweeping accusation generates millions of views, comments and response videos, the creator receives a commercial lesson. The next post can be more absolute, more personal and more antagonistic.

This adaptation does not require deep ideological commitment. It can be ordinary market behaviour. Creators need attention to secure sponsorships, subscriptions, speaking opportunities, coaching clients and sales of books or courses. Gender grievance is especially monetizable because it offers recurring problems with purchasable solutions: confidence training, dating strategy, femininity coaching, masculinity programmes, divorce advice, private communities and lifestyle products.

The result is a two-level market. Platforms monetize the audience's attention and behavioural data; creators monetize the audience's insecurity, resentment or desire for belonging. Over time, successful creators become polarization entrepreneurs - not necessarily because they invented the grievance, but because they package it in the form most compatible with platform distribution.

8. From Engagement to Perceived Social Reality

The social harm is not limited to offensive content. Recommendation systems can distort a user's estimate of what other people believe. Brady and colleagues found that observers systematically overestimated the moral outrage expressed by social-media users; this overperception inflated beliefs about hostile communication norms, ideological extremity and conflict between groups (Brady et al., 2023).

Applied to gender discourse, a feed filled with the most provocative male and female voices may be mistaken for a representative survey of society. A young man may conclude that most women despise ordinary men; a young woman may conclude that most men secretly endorse coercion or domination. The feed is not a neutral sample. It is an optimized sequence selected partly because previous users reacted strongly to it.

This creates a feedback loop between perception and production. Users who believe the opposite gender is hostile become more receptive to defensive or retaliatory content. Creators respond with stronger narratives. The recommendation system receives fresh evidence that the topic retains attention. What began as a selection bias can therefore contribute to real hostility, mistrust and withdrawal from relationships.

9. Counterarguments and Evidentiary Limits

A credible analysis must resist three overstatements. First, engagement is not the only ranking objective. Platforms use integrity rules, user controls, surveys, moderation systems and other measures that may down-rank harmful material. Second, not all exposure changes beliefs. Some major studies of political content have found limited or mixed effects of feed changes on attitudes, and the relationship between online exposure and durable polarization remains contested. Third, users and wider social institutions are not passive. Gender conflict draws upon economic insecurity, dating-market change, family experience, political organizing and long-standing inequalities that exist beyond social media.

The article also does not calculate a causal revenue contribution from gender-polarizing content. Public financial data are aggregated across products and topics. A rigorous estimate would require content classification, randomized or quasi-experimental variation in recommendations, exposure and advertisement logs, advertiser pricing data, and controls for user self-selection. Without such access, the profit claim should be understood as an incentive-based explanation rather than a completed accounting exercise.

Finally, criticism should not collapse all gender advocacy into polarization. Content concerning violence against women, male suicide, unequal labour, false allegations, reproductive rights or family-law reform may be uncomfortable yet socially necessary. The relevant distinction is not between calm and controversial speech. It is between evidence-based advocacy and a commercial style that converts complex problems into permanent hostility toward an entire gender.

10. Reducing the Profitability of Division

The problem cannot be solved only by deleting individual posts. When the underlying reward system remains unchanged, replacement content will appear. A more durable response must address platform design, creator incentives and user interpretation together.

- Measure and publish topic-level amplification data. Independent researchers should be able to compare the organic prevalence of gender-hostile content with its prevalence after recommendation ranking.
- Audit engagement objectives against reflective user preferences. Platforms should test whether users value the content they are predicted to engage with, rather than assuming that a click or comment represents satisfaction.
- Reduce the influence of repeat extreme accounts. The 2026 Nature study suggests that diversifying feeds away from extreme users can reduce toxic exposure while maintaining comparable enjoyment.
- Introduce friction for reactive redistribution. Prompts before reposting, context labels and limits on repetitive recommendation may reduce the second-hand circulation through which opposing communities monetize one another.
- Reward constructive disagreement. Creator programmes can incorporate indicators of accuracy, cross-group understanding and audience well-being rather than relying predominantly on volume-based performance.
- Build gender-aware digital literacy. Users should be taught that a personalized feed is not a representative sample of men, women or society, and that outrage can be selected because it performs rather than because it is typical.

11. Conclusion

The most important insight is not that social-media companies secretly instruct users to hate the opposite gender. It is that an advertising-funded attention system can convert social division into useful input. Gender antagonism supplies emotionally charged stories; user reactions supply behavioural signals; recommendation systems expand distribution; creators intensify what performs; and advertising turns the resulting attention into revenue.

Meta's disclosures demonstrate the scale and efficiency of this architecture: advertising represents nearly all company revenue, while ranking changes can increase views, time spent, clicks and conversions. Research on moral-emotional diffusion and engagement-based feeds shows why divisive material can gain an advantage within such systems. Emerging gender-specific audits indicate that these mechanisms can intersect with misogynistic and gender-hostile pathways, although the evidence remains incomplete and uneven.

Gender conflict existed before social media and would survive without it. What platforms change is its speed, repetition, personalization and commercial durability. The policy challenge is therefore not merely to remove the worst content after it becomes visible. It is to redesign the market so that understanding people is at least as valuable as dividing them.

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Declarations

Conflict of interest

The author declares no known financial or personal conflict of interest relevant to this article.

Data availability

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